approaching it. There is no reason for us to help the Americans on Cuba.'[54] And, as a nation dependent on maritime trade, the British were sensitive to any attempt to interfere with what they saw as the freedom of the seas. Macmillan had also taken personal affront at what he saw as Kennedy's breaking of a promise involving the sale of surface-to-air missiles to Israel.

Kennedy's unwillingness to consult over an air strike extended to the blockade. On the day of the televised speech, on 22 October, US emissaries arrived in London, Paris, Bonn, and Ottawa to brief NATO leaders. When Dean Acheson arrived at the Elysée Palace, President de Gaulle began by asking, 'Are you consulting me or informing me?'[55] For Harold Macmillan, consultation was of domestic political importance. The Labour Party and other critics were keen to cast doubt on the suggestion that Macmillan's government carried weight in any 'special relationship' with Washington. There was also criticism that Britain's possession of nuclear weapons had not bought access to counsels of war in Washington.

One surprising aspect of the crisis was that news of the missiles did not leak in Washington. This was important in enabling Kennedy to think through his reaction and dampen the tempers of the moment. JFK also relaxed his approach to the British. On 19 October the CIA Deputy Director of Intelligence, Ray Cline, was authorised to brief senior British officials about the missiles. Major-General Sir Kenneth Strong, Director of the Joint Intelligence Bureau, Burke Trend, the Cabinet Secretary-designate, and Sir Hugh Stephenson, Chairman of the Joint Intelligence Committee (along with Thomas Brimelow from the British embassy) were, by coincidence, attending a conference on intelligence methodology at Langley. Cline told Strong and Trend what had been discovered in Cuba. There was an expectation among US officials that this news would quickly reach London. When Macmillan learned exactly, however, is unclear.

Having an old friend for lunch

Kennedy's intentions were made clear to the British ambassador on Sunday, 21 October, when Kennedy invited Sir David Ormsby-Gore to 'come unseen' to the White House just before lunch.[56] Jack and David went back a